

# BABOU'S KINGDOM

DISCUSSION & CLASSROOM RESOURCE PACK

For children aged approximately 8–12

**HOME → LEAVING → JOURNEY → BELONGING → HOPE**

*Exploring displacement, courage, compassion and belonging through story*

*A free learning resource to accompany Babou's Kingdom*

# Welcome

Babou's Kingdom is first and foremost an adventure. It follows a child whose world changes suddenly and who must find a way forward through uncertainty, danger, friendship and hope.

Babou's journey also creates an opportunity to explore experiences that affect children and families in the real world. Children may hear words such as war, refugee, migrant, border and asylum through television, social media or conversations around them without fully understanding what those words can mean for the people experiencing them.

## THE IDEA AT THE HEART OF THIS PACK

Rather than beginning with statistics or politics, Babou's Kingdom invites children to begin with one child: what home meant to him, what it felt like to lose familiar people and places, who helped him, and what it means to belong.

This resource is designed for teachers, librarians, parents and other adults. It can be used after reading the whole book, alongside selected parts of the story, in a book group, during a lesson, or at home.

You do not need to complete every activity. Choose the sections that work best for your children or setting.

## Five themes guide the pack:

**HOME → LEAVING → JOURNEY → BELONGING → HOPE**

The aim is not to provide every answer. It is to encourage children to think, talk, draw, write, ask questions and consider experiences different from their own.

## Using the book sensitively

- Never require children to share personal experiences of war, migration, separation, discrimination or displacement.
- Allow different emotions. Sadness, curiosity, anger, uncertainty and discomfort can all be part of learning.
- Keep the focus on people and human experience rather than asking children to debate political positions.
- Remind children that difficult stories can also contain friendship, humour, imagination, kindness and hope.

## KEY CONCEPTS

# Words We Hear

These explanations are deliberately simple. Formal definitions are more detailed, but these versions give children a useful starting point.

## HOME

A place can be home, but home can also mean the people, memories, languages, foods, sounds, traditions and routines that make somewhere feel familiar and safe.

## DISPLACEMENT

Someone is displaced when they have been forced to leave the place where they normally live. This can happen because of conflict, violence, persecution or disaster. They may move elsewhere within their own country or cross a border.

## REFUGEE

A refugee is a person who is outside their country and needs international protection because returning would put their life, safety or freedom at serious risk.

## ASYLUM SEEKER

An asylum seeker is someone seeking protection in another country while their claim for protection is being considered, or someone who intends to seek that protection.

## MIGRATION

Migration is a broad word for movement from one place to another. People move for many reasons - including family, work, study, opportunity and safety. The word migrant does not have one single definition in international law.

## BELONGING

Belonging is the feeling that there is a place for you. It can come from family, friendship, community, culture, language or simply knowing that you are welcomed and accepted.

### A USEFUL DISTINCTION

Not everyone who moves country is a refugee, and not everyone who is displaced crosses a border. The words describe different experiences and legal situations.

## Before reading: questions to begin with

**What makes somewhere feel like home?**

**What makes somewhere feel safe?**

**Can somebody be frightened and brave at the same time?**

**Why might somebody have to leave somewhere they love?**

**What helps a person feel welcome?**

HOME IS MORE THAN A BUILDING

# 1. HOME

Before Babou has a journey, he has a home. That matters. People who become refugees or displaced people are sometimes spoken about only in terms of what happened to them. But before someone was displaced, they had a life: friends, family, routines, favourite places, languages, food, celebrations, hobbies and dreams.

## Think about Babou

**What do you think home means to Babou?**

**Which memories might he want to hold onto?**

**What ordinary things might he miss?**

**Why can small familiar things become especially important when everything else changes?**

### ACTIVITY: MY MAP OF HOME

In the centre of a page, write HOME. Around it, draw or write the people, places, sounds, foods, languages, objects, traditions and memories that make home feel like home to you.

**Choose one item from your map. Why is it important to you? How would you feel if you could not experience it for a long time?**

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## Discuss together

**Did everyone choose the same things? What does this tell us about what “home” can mean?**

### ADULT NOTE

Children do not need to reveal private information. They can create an imaginary “home map” for a fictional character if they prefer.

WHEN LEAVING IS NOT REALLY A CHOICE

## 2. LEAVING

Sometimes people decide to move. Other times, staying becomes unsafe. Conflict, persecution, violence or danger can force people to leave homes and communities they love.

Leaving does not mean somebody has stopped loving their home. Sometimes leaving is something people do because they need to survive or protect the people they care about.

### Think about Babou

**Did Babou choose the journey he found himself on?**

**What choices did he have?**

**What did he lose by leaving?**

**What might he carry with him that cannot be packed into a bag?**

#### SIGNATURE ACTIVITY: WHAT WOULD YOU TAKE?

Imagine you have to leave home unexpectedly. You do not know exactly where you are going or how long you will be away. You can take only THREE things.

**1. My item:** \_\_\_\_\_

Why is it important?

\_\_\_\_\_

**2. My item:** \_\_\_\_\_

Why is it important?

\_\_\_\_\_

**3. My item:** \_\_\_\_\_

Why is it important?

\_\_\_\_\_

**Now look at your choices. Did you choose something practical, something valuable, something that reminds you of someone, or something that simply makes you feel safe?**

**What important things cannot be packed at all - friendships, language, neighbourhoods, memories, routines or a sense of belonging?**

COURAGE, UNCERTAINTY AND KINDNESS

### 3. THE JOURNEY

Leaving home is not always the end of the difficult part. A journey may involve unfamiliar places, separation, waiting, borders, strangers and difficult decisions. People may sometimes depend on the kindness of people they have never met before.

Babou's journey is fictional, but it allows us to explore very real human emotions: fear, uncertainty, trust, friendship, courage, kindness and hope.

#### What is courage?

**Does feeling afraid mean Babou is not brave?**

**Can courage mean continuing even when you are frightened?**

**Can asking for help be courageous?**

**Can helping another person require courage?**

#### FINISH THE SENTENCE

Courage is...

#### Activity: Help Along the Way

##### WHAT MADE THINGS HARDER?

Actions, situations or experiences that increased Babou's fear or difficulty.

##### WHAT MADE THINGS EASIER?

Kindness, friendship, protection, sharing, encouragement or trust.

**Can one small act make a big difference to someone who feels frightened or alone?**

SAFETY AND BELONGING ARE NOT ALWAYS THE SAME THING

## 4. BELONGING

Imagine arriving somewhere where you do not know anyone, people speak differently from you, the school works differently, the food is unfamiliar and you miss people you love. You might be safe, but you might still feel very far from home.

Belonging often grows slowly. It can begin when somebody learns your name, invites you to join a game, sits beside you, explains something kindly, or simply makes it clear: there is a place for you here.

### ACTIVITY: THE WELCOME KIT

Imagine a child has just joined your school after arriving from another country. You do not know why they moved, and you should not assume. Create five simple things your class could do to help the new pupil feel welcome.

1. \_\_\_\_\_
2. \_\_\_\_\_
3. \_\_\_\_\_
4. \_\_\_\_\_
5. \_\_\_\_\_

### Now think carefully

**Which of your ideas cost money? Which cost nothing? Which could your class begin tomorrow?**

### A question about curiosity

It is natural to be curious about somebody new. But there is a difference between welcoming someone and making them feel that they have to explain themselves.

### COMPARE THESE

“Where are you really from?”

“Would you like to sit with us?”

**How might each question make somebody feel? How can we show interest without asking someone to share things they may not want to discuss?**

A STORY CAN HOLD DIFFICULT THINGS AND HOPE AT THE SAME TIME

## 5. HOPE

Hope does not mean pretending something difficult never happened. It does not mean Babou has to stop missing people, and it does not mean everything suddenly becomes easy.

Hope can be smaller: a new friendship, someone sharing food, remembering someone you love, finding somewhere to rest, being welcomed, laughing again, imagining tomorrow, or discovering that your story is not finished.

### ACTIVITY: A SYMBOL OF HOPE

If hope were an object or symbol, what would it look like? It might be a light, a road, a tree, a bird, a doorway, a crown, a sunrise - or something completely different.

**My symbol of hope is:** \_\_\_\_\_

It represents hope because...

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### Babou's crown

A crown usually makes us think of kings, queens, power or something precious. But Babou's crown is not perfect.

**Why do you think the crown matters?**

**Can something broken still be valuable?**

**Can something damaged still tell an important story?**

**What might Babou's crown tell us about him?**

### DESIGN CHALLENGE

Design your own crown. Instead of jewels, decorate it with symbols of things you believe are truly valuable: family, friendship, courage, home, kindness, identity, hope - or your own ideas.



WRITING, IMAGINING AND DISCUSSING

# Creative Responses

## Babou's Diary

Choose one moment from Babou's journey. Imagine he has found a quiet place and a few minutes to write. Begin with "Dear Diary," and include something he can see, something he can hear, something he remembers, something he fears and something he hopes will happen next.

### WRITING TIP

People can feel more than one emotion at once. Babou might be frightened AND determined, sad AND hopeful, or lonely AND grateful for friendship.

## A Letter of Welcome

Imagine Babou is going to arrive in your town and join your school. Write him a letter. Tell him something useful, something kind and something that would help him know he does not have to face everything alone.

## Discussion cards

### HOME

What makes somewhere feel like home?

### FRIENDSHIP

Which relationship made the biggest difference to Babou?

### BELONGING

What helps someone feel that they belong?

### HOPE

Where did you notice hope in Babou's story?

### COURAGE

When was Babou most courageous?

### CHOICE

Which parts of Babou's journey could he control, and which could he not?

### IDENTITY

If you move somewhere new, do you have to leave your old identity behind?

### THE FUTURE

What do you think Babou will do next?

THERE MAY BE MORE THAN ONE USEFUL ANSWER

# Talk It Through

## True, false or “it depends”?

For each statement, choose TRUE, FALSE or IT DEPENDS - and explain why. The explanation matters more than guessing.

- ☐ **TRUE**   ☐ **FALSE**   ☐ **IT DEPENDS**   Everyone who moves to another country is a refugee.
- ☐ **TRUE**   ☐ **FALSE**   ☐ **IT DEPENDS**   Everyone who leaves their country wanted to leave.
- ☐ **TRUE**   ☐ **FALSE**   ☐ **IT DEPENDS**   Someone can miss their old home and enjoy their new home at the same time.
- ☐ **TRUE**   ☐ **FALSE**   ☐ **IT DEPENDS**   Courage means never being frightened.
- ☐ **TRUE**   ☐ **FALSE**   ☐ **IT DEPENDS**   You have to speak the same language to show somebody kindness.
- ☐ **TRUE**   ☐ **FALSE**   ☐ **IT DEPENDS**   A person can have more than one place that feels like home.
- ☐ **TRUE**   ☐ **FALSE**   ☐ **IT DEPENDS**   Small acts can help people feel that they belong.
- ☐ **TRUE**   ☐ **FALSE**   ☐ **IT DEPENDS**   Two people can experience the same journey very differently.

## For families

You do not need to turn Babou's Kingdom into a lesson at home. Sometimes a conversation is enough. Try one or two of these questions and allow the conversation to happen naturally.

**Which part of Babou's journey stayed in your mind?**

**Which character did you care about most?**

**What do you think Babou misses?**

**What do you think kept him going?**

**Did anything in the story make you think differently about children affected by war?**

**What could help somebody arriving somewhere new feel welcome?**

**What do you think will happen in the next Babou story?**

### A GENTLE REMINDER

Children do not always want to answer immediately. Interesting conversations often happen later - at bedtime, in the car, on a walk or when something on the news reminds them of the story.

## POSSIBLE LEARNING LINKS AND A READY-TO-USE LESSON

# For Teachers

## Possible curriculum links

|                               |                                                                                                                                       |
|-------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ENGLISH & LITERACY            | Character, perspective, inference, emotional vocabulary, diary writing, letter writing, prediction, symbolism, discussion and debate. |
| PSHE / PERSONAL DEVELOPMENT   | Empathy, identity, relationships, inclusion, communities, managing feelings, helping others and belonging.                            |
| GEOGRAPHY                     | Countries and borders, movement of people, journeys, place, identity and human geography.                                             |
| ART                           | Symbols of hope, visual storytelling, the meaning of objects, drawing “home”, and crown design.                                       |
| CITIZENSHIP / GLOBAL LEARNING | Refugees, displacement, asylum, migration, children’s rights, conflict and welcoming newcomers.                                       |

## Suggested 60-minute class session

- 1. HOME - 10 min** What makes somewhere feel like home? Create a class mind map.
- 2. BABOU - 10 min** Discuss what Babou loses when he has to leave - not only possessions, but people, routines and familiarity.
- 3. WHAT WOULD YOU TAKE? - 15 min** Children select three objects and explain their choices.
- 4. DISCUSSION - 10 min** What important things cannot be packed into a bag?
- 5. BELONGING - 10 min** Create five actions that could help a newcomer feel welcome.
- 6. HOPE - 5 min** Complete: “One thing I learned from Babou’s journey is...”

## AN EXTENDED FIVE-SESSION PROJECT

# Home to Hope

**SESSION 1 - HOME** Explore identity, memory and what makes somewhere feel familiar. *Activity: My Map of Home*

**SESSION 2 - LEAVING** Explore choice, forced movement and the meaning of displacement. *Activity: What Would You Take?*

**SESSION 3 - JOURNEY** Explore courage, uncertainty and kindness. *Activity: Help Along the Way*

**SESSION 4 - BELONGING** Explore inclusion and welcoming newcomers. *Activity: The Welcome Kit*

**SESSION 5 - HOPE** Explore resilience, future possibilities and what children have learned. *Activity: A Symbol of Hope*

## CLASSROOM DISPLAY

Finish by creating a shared display: HOME → LEAVING → JOURNEY → BELONGING → HOPE. Children can contribute drawings, writing and reflections from each session.

## A final thought for children

Babou is one character in one story. Real children who experience war or displacement are all different. Some are frightened. Some are funny. Some are quiet. Some are adventurous. Some love football. Some love books. Some miss home. Some are excited about their future. Some may feel many of those things at once.

Being a refugee is something that may be part of a person's life. It is not everything that person is.

When we learn about difficult events, it can be easy to see crowds, numbers or labels. Stories remind us to look closer. Behind every number is a person. Behind every journey is a life. And every child has a story bigger than the label somebody gives them.

## Further learning for adults and educators

### UNHCR - Teaching About Refugees

Age-appropriate teaching materials on refugees, asylum and migration, including resources for ages 9–12. [www.unhcr.org/teaching-about-refugees](http://www.unhcr.org/teaching-about-refugees)

### Amnesty International UK - Refugee Rights Primary Pack

A teaching resource for primary schools exploring why people flee, refugee rights, migration and welcome. [www.amnesty.org.uk](http://www.amnesty.org.uk)

### UNICEF

Information and resources about children affected by conflict, emergencies and displacement. [www.unicef.org](http://www.unicef.org)

## Notes for adults

The explanations in this pack have been simplified for younger readers. For formal legal definitions, consult authoritative sources such as UNHCR. Babou's Kingdom is a work of fiction; no single fictional character can represent the experiences of all refugees, migrants or displaced children. The purpose of this resource is to encourage curiosity, empathy, discussion and further learning.